



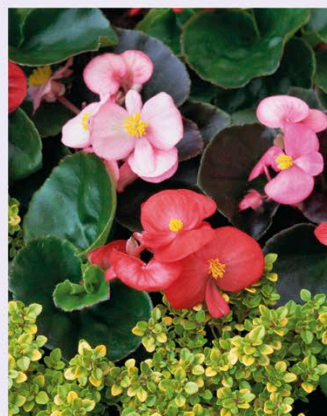
Plant focus: begonias

Sporting colorful flowers and patterned leaves, begonias are ideal plants for shady summer container and bedding displays.

MOST BEGONIAS ARE TENDER PERENNIALS, grown in shady summer gardens. The rex and rhizomatous forms, with their colorful, intricately patterned foliage, create dramatic displays in pots. The trailing pendula group offers both foliage and flower interest, and makes excellent hanging basket plants, while the taller, upright cane-forming hybrids and large-flowered tuberous types are perfect for larger summer containers. The compact Semperflorens begonias, often sold as bedding, produce a frill of colorful flowers around beds and borders. Most begonias thrive in warm, sheltered, shady gardens; where temperatures dip below 50°F (10°C) for long periods in summer, grow plants in a sunroom or indoors. Many dislike wet soil, so avoid overwatering them. Apply a balanced fertilizer weekly when plants are in full growth. Water evergreens sparingly in winter and store the dormant tubers of deciduous plants in a cool, dry, frost-free place—repot in late spring and plant outside when the risk of frost has passed.

USING BEGONIAS

In cool areas, begonias are best grown on an outdoor windowsill where the heat of the building provides additional warmth and encourages the plants to bloom. Trailing begonias are suitable for hanging baskets and tall pots, but give them a sheltered position to prevent damage to the brittle leaves and stems. Keep plants well watered during summer.



Semperflorens begonias tolerate some sun and can be used as decorative edging plants or as the ingredients for a traditional bedding scheme.

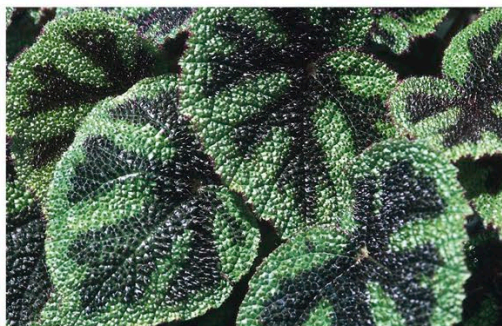
Rex-cultorum begonias, with their large ornamental leaves, offer a textural contrast to colorful foliage plants, such as coleus, in a contemporary patio container display.



POPULAR BEGONIA SPECIES



Rex-cultorum begonias These perennials, mostly evergreens, have colorful foliage, which is often arranged on plants in a spiral pattern. Small inconspicuous flowers appear in spring.



Rhizomatous begonias These are grown for their decorative, mostly evergreen leaves, which are often arranged in spirals, have unusual textures, and feature colorful markings.



Semperflorens begonias These compact, bushy evergreen perennials, often grown as annuals, have rounded, bronze or green leaves and small single or double summer flowers.